

The Do No Harm Framework: A Comprehensive Guide to Conflict-Sensitive Humanitarian Aid

Introduction

In the world of humanitarian assistance, the principle of "Do No Harm" represents a fundamental commitment: to provide aid in a manner that maximizes positive impact without making the situation worse. Each day, millions of people worldwide face devastating circumstances — hunger, thirst, poverty, homelessness, and danger arising from geographical conditions, natural disasters, violence, and war. Aid workers across the globe are united by a common goal: to help those in need while ensuring that their interventions do not inadvertently cause harm.

This article presents a comprehensive overview of the Do No Harm Framework, a conflict sensitivity tool developed by the Collaborative for Development Action (CDA) that provides aid organizations with a structured methodology for analyzing and mitigating the unintended consequences of humanitarian interventions in conflict-affected settings.

The Foundation: What is "Do No Harm"?

The principle of "Do No Harm," in its broadest application, means providing aid in a manner that maximizes its positive impact and does not make the situation worse. While this serves as a solid premise for delivering aid of any type, it does not, on its own, provide a detailed guide for preparing and delivering aid — especially in conflict settings.

To address this gap, the Do No Harm Framework for Analyzing the Impact of Aid on Conflict was developed. This framework equips aid workers with practical tools to understand how their programs interact with the social, political, and economic dynamics of the communities they serve.

Why is Conflict Sensitivity Important?

Conflict exists throughout society between individuals and groups. It can generate thoughtful debate and produce positive outcomes. However, it can also lead to misunderstanding, tension, and violence. The Do No Harm approach focuses specifically on **destructive conflict** — the kind that harms communities and undermines stability.

By applying Do No Harm principles, aid workers learn to avoid unintentionally exacerbating destructive conflicts while promoting three key organizational values:

Principle	Definition
Effectiveness	Encouraging organizations to tailor their interventions to the specific contexts in which they operate.
Accountability	Requiring that organizations respond to any unintentional negative impacts created by their interventions, and encouraging local voices and priorities in programming.
Efficiency	Helping implementers foresee and prevent unintended negative impacts, enabling smoother implementation with greater support from local communities.

The Do No Harm Conflict Sensitivity Tool

How does one begin to develop a conflict-sensitive approach to providing aid? The process begins with understanding three foundational elements:

1. **The context** in which your aid program is operating.
2. **How the program interacts** with that context.
3. **Acting in a manner** that minimizes negative impacts and maximizes positive impacts.

The Six Universal Lessons of Do No Harm

Through extensive case study research involving thousands of aid workers, donors, and community members, six universal lessons emerged:

Lesson 1: When an intervention of any kind enters a context, it becomes part of that context. An aid intervention becomes part of the context and results in both positive and negative effects. For example, distributing food can decrease malnutrition while simultaneously increasing crime if not done thoughtfully.

Lesson 2: Every context has dividers and connectors. These are factors that either create tension among people and groups or bring them together. These factors can be social, political, or economic.

Lesson 3: All interventions will interact with both dividers and connectors, making them better or worse. Aid interventions impact both dividers and connectors. For example, distributing food to those in need can inadvertently favor one group over another depending upon where and when it is done.

Lesson 4: Interventions interact with dividers and connectors through organizational actions and the behavior of staff. Aid interacts with dividers and connectors based upon predictable patterns of impact called *actions* and *behaviors*. Actions are the resources (such as food or skills) you bring into a context, while behaviors are the messages your work conveys to people.

Lesson 5: The details of an intervention are the source of its impacts. An entire intervention is rarely responsible for negative impacts on dividers and connectors. It is the smaller details that often carry the greatest weight. For example, where you choose to distribute food can favor the group closest to the distribution point.

Lesson 6: There are always options for changing your aid program to reduce its negative impact. For example, the distribution point for aid can be centralized so it does not favor one group over another.

Understanding Dividers and Connectors

Conflicts are characterized by dividers and connectors. These are not abstract concepts — they are tangible, observable factors that shape the dynamics within a community.

Dividers are factors that increase the level of tension, division, suspicion, mistrust, inequality, or capacity for war between groups. For example, resources like a water pump can become a source of tension or division between groups if they are not provided with equal access.

Connectors are factors that decrease these effects and promote trust, tolerance, cooperation, and the peaceful resolution of conflict. For example, a school can be a unifying institution that brings together people of varied backgrounds.

These factors can be **social, political, or economic** in nature, encompassing elements such as physical geography, population composition, social structure, environment, geostrategic position, emergent political and economic issues, conflict-prone areas, and history of conflict.

Can a Connector Also Be a Divider?

The answer is: yes, and no. This question illustrates the critical importance of establishing boundaries for analysis. If you are analyzing a single village, you may identify water as a shared resource among all villagers — a connector. However, if you expand the analysis to a

group of nearby villages, there may be competition for that same resource, transforming water into a divider.

The Five Categories of Dividers and Connectors

Societies function through systems and organize to govern themselves through institutions. These structures serve as powerful forces that either help to connect groups or promote difference and division between them. Systems and institutions can be inclusive or exclusive, legitimate for all or only for some, formal or informal.

Examples of systems and institutions include: police stations, daycare programs for children, religious sites or places of worship, neighborhood committees, clubs or community networks, crisis and emergency plans in the community, and systems for water distribution.

When analyzing these categories, practitioners should ask:

Which of these systems and institutions keep people apart or increase tensions between groups? Which help people overcome differences or promote coexistence?

Patterns of Impact: Actions and Behaviors

Aid programs show distinct patterns of positive and negative impact on the contexts in which they work. These impacts are the result of actions and behaviors by the organization and its staff.

What Are Actions?

Actions are resources an organization transfers into a context and the activities involved in making those transfers. They affect the equality and security of dividers and connectors. Examples of resources include food, goods, money, shelter, skills, and advocacy.

When a context is low on resources, the resource becomes a source of wealth and power — potentially becoming part of the conflict and a method for manipulating a cause. For example, food brought into a context to mitigate hunger can be stolen and used to fund conflict between groups. In this case, the food has a **dividing** impact on relationships.

What Are Behaviors?

Behavior sends messages that can either reinforce the moods and modes of destructive conflict or promote ethics that strengthen peaceful coexistence. The way staff treat community members, the language they use, and the values they demonstrate all convey implicit ethical messages that shape how the intervention is perceived.

Positive Patterns of Impact

The most effective aid organizations link their programs to context analysis and monitor changes within the context to increase their likelihood of generating positive patterns of impact:

- Negative impacts are identified and lessened.
- Positive impacts are preserved, built upon, or increased.
- Context-appropriate interventions are chosen.
- Policies for interacting constructively with local communities and colleagues are developed.
- Options for improving program impact are more easily identified.

The Five Steps of Program Analysis

Program analysis serves to maximize the positive impact of an aid program on intergroup relationships. Most aid programs can change intervention details without altering their mandate and structure or incurring significantly larger costs.

Step	Key Question	Considerations
1. Who	Who are we working with?	Staff, beneficiaries, partners, authorities
2. Where	Where are we working?	Office location, meeting sites, advertising and distribution locations
3. What	What are we doing?	Goals, required resources, appropriateness, acceptability to all groups
4. When	When is our intervention taking place?	Context-based timeframes, time of day, season, post-emergency/post-conflict stage
5. Why	Why and how did we select our intervention?	Available options, organizational capacity, transparency, defining success

Program Options and Continuous Adaptation

Even the most thorough program analysis cannot predict every outcome. Change occurs over time, and negative impacts may arise even with the best intentions. Therefore, organizations should regularly review dividers and connectors for changes and adapt their programs accordingly.

A regular review process helps develop alternatives to minimize adverse effects and maximize positive impact on intergroup relationships. Most often, small changes to program details can be made without jeopardizing the organization's mission or the intervention's goals.

Steps to Generate Program Options

The process of generating program options follows a cyclical approach:

1. **Review** — Regularly review dividers and connectors for changes.
 2. **Evaluate/Identify** — Assess and identify patterns of impact.
 3. **Change** — Modify the patterns of impact. Work with your team and local people to gain more perspective and ideas. Generate a list of many options, then narrow it to a few feasible ones given available resources.
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A Practical Case Study

To illustrate these principles in action, consider the following scenario:

Two neighboring villages, Anita and Brando, were divided by a conflict between communist forces and opposition forces. Villages on both sides were looted and burned during the war, displacing many families and leaving them homeless and hungry. The local cotton industry, the chief source of employment, was destroyed.

After the war, Brando refugees returned to find their homes occupied by Anita families. Community leaders established committees to settle housing disputes. An international aid organization, "Help Us," identified food shortages and destroyed homes as the primary problems and instituted a Food for Work program to repair or rebuild houses.

The workforce consisted mainly of Brando people, who had experienced the most damage to their homes. Over time, 12,000 homes were repaired or rebuilt — most belonging to Brando families. However, Anita people participated in fewer numbers, saw fewer homes rebuilt, and experienced ongoing malnutrition. The intervention, while well-intentioned, inadvertently created a new imbalance.

This case study demonstrates the critical importance of analyzing dividers and connectors before implementing aid programs, and of continuously adapting based on observed impacts.

Conclusion

The Do No Harm Framework is a powerful tool that organizations use to apply conflict sensitivity to interventions within contexts where intergroup conflict exists. It enables programs to become more **effective, accountable, and efficient** by systematically analyzing the complex dynamics between aid interventions and the communities they serve.

Dividers and connectors are the fundamental factors influencing a context and an intervention's effectiveness. Organizations and their staff affect these factors through their **actions** (the resources they transfer) and **behaviors** (the messages they convey). No matter what challenges arise, there are always options for making changes to an aid program to maximize its positive effects.

Conflict sensitivity is not merely a theoretical concept — it is a practical, actionable methodology that empowers humanitarian practitioners to build peace, one carefully analyzed intervention at a time.

This article is based on the Do No Harm Framework for Analyzing the Impact of Aid on Conflict, developed by the Collaborative for Development Action (CDA).